TECHNIQUES/DEVICES AND METHODS

There are different techniques of maintaining the balance of power system. These are now briefly discussed.

1. ***Alliances and Counter-Alliances:*** These are the most commonly used devices for maintaining the balance of power. If one state increases its strength, its adversaries have no other option but to balance it by forming coalitions against it. This has happened quite often in Europe, where, whenever one particular state threatened the balance in Europe, other states formed coalitions against it. Coalitions of one group of states may be met by counter-coalitions formed by another group of states. Twentieth century Europe saw two such alliances and counter-alliances, one of them being the Triple Entente formed by France, England and Russia in 1907 as a response to the Triple Alliance of Imperial Germany, Austria–Hungary and Italy. Another was the Axis formed in 1936 to counter the alliance between France and European nations. Again, the Allied powers formed a coalition against the Axis power during the Second World War.

Alliances can be both offensive and defensive, and even a world balance or a regional balance. It is not too much to say that balance of power considerations, whether regional, hemispheric or worldwide, are a controlling factor in virtually every alliance formed by states. This has proved to be true during the Cold War days when the United States formed several military regional arrangements such as NATO, SEATO, CENTO and others, with West European States, Central Asian states and Pakistan, which were countered by Soviet led coalitions like the WARSAW Pact.

2. ***Compensations:*** Morgenthau points out that “the bargaining of diplomatic negotiations issuing in political compromise is but the principle of compensation in the most general form, and as such it is originally connected with the balance of power”. Compensation usually involves annexation or division of territory. Territorial compensations have been frequently used by powerful states at the expense of the smaller and weaker ones and by victorious powers at the end of a war. Between 1870 and 1914, this principle was applied